

Presentation Outline

Over 70% of college instructors in America are contingent faculty.

AAUP (American Association of University Professors) Background Facts on Contingent Faculty Positions:
"Contingent" faculty positions include both part- and full-time non-tenure-track appointments

- 49 percent part time and 19 percent full-time non-tenure-track
- Other part-time appointments are held by graduate student employees, whose chances of obtaining tenure-track positions in the future are increasingly uncertain. What is billed as a teaching apprenticeship often instead amounts to years of intensive, low-paid work that distracts from, rather than complementing, graduate studies.
- Their common characteristic is that institutions make little or no long-term commitment to faculty holding these positions.

We will examine what this exploitation costs students, the severe mental health consequences adjuncts endure, the starvation wages they receive despite advanced degrees, the structural causes of this systematic shift, and concrete solutions for meaningful reform.

Today's college students pay record tuition to be taught by those they underpay, overwork, and undervalue rather than the faculty universities advertise. To understand this injustice, we must first see what it costs students — and what it costs the teachers who serve them.

When Instructors Suffer, Students Lose

Lost Mentorship

- Students bond with instructors who vanish the next semester.
- High turnover destroys the continuity of mentoring relationships essential for student success and retention.
- The high turnover among contingent faculty members mean that students in a department may never have the same teacher twice, or may be unable to find an instructor who knows them well enough to write a letter of recommendation. (AAUP (American Association of University Professors) Background Facts on Contingent Faculty Positions)

Curriculum

- Curriculum incoherence increases as courses are handed off semester to semester
- Adjuncts are often hired on the spur of the moment with little evaluation or time to prepare-- sometimes after a semester has already started. (AAUP (American Association of University Professors) Background Facts on Contingent Faculty Positions)
- Proportionally fewer tenure-track faculty means fewer people to divide up the work of advising students, setting curriculum, and serving on college-wide committees. (AAUP (American Association of University Professors) Background Facts on Contingent Faculty Positions)

AAUP (American Association of University Professors) Background Facts on Contingent Faculty Positions:
Many institutions have invested heavily in facilities and technology while cutting instructional spending.

Though incoming students may find finer facilities, they are also likely to find fewer full-time faculty with adequate time, professional support, and resources available for their instruction.

Bait & Switch

- Universities market their tenured, research-prominent faculty in recruitment materials
- In reality, most undergraduate instruction is delivered by adjuncts — a "bait-and-switch" that undermines trust and educational quality (Umbach 2007; Figlio et al. 2015)

Disproportionate Impact

- Students at community colleges and in lower-level undergraduate courses are disproportionately taught by faculty on contingent appointments. (AAUP (American Association of University Professors) Background Facts on Contingent Faculty Positions)
- 70–90% adjunct rates at community colleges (Phillippe, Kent DataPoints: Trends among Adjunct/Part-Time Instructors Mar. 2024)

A Two-Tiered Caste System

The "Temporary" Myth

AFT 2020 study reports:

- 40% have been teaching in higher education for >15 years
 - 37% cannot imagine how they will retire
 - 63% are >50 years old
- CFT 2022:
- 35% have more than 15 years
 - only 23% have less than five years
 - three-quarters would take more work if offered

AAUP (American Association of University Professors) Background Facts on Contingent Faculty Positions:

While a small percentage of part-time faculty are specialists or practitioners of a profession such as law or architecture and teach a class on the side, this situation is the exception rather than the norm.

In other words, contingent faculty are "real" faculty, not other professionals who are moonlighting by teaching a course.

Many faculty in so-called "part-time" positions actually teach the equivalent of a full-time course load.

Pay

- More than 25% of adjuncts earn less than \$26,500 annually, which is below the federal poverty guideline for a family of four ("New AFT Report: Adjunct Faculty Remain Underpaid" 2023)
- Only 15% of adjuncts report being able to comfortably cover their basic monthly expenses (AFT 2020)
- Roughly 74% of adjuncts live paycheck to paycheck, with more than a third unable to cover all their monthly bills
- Some teach up to six courses per semester—nearly double a typical full-time professor's load—just to reach survival-level income

To support themselves, part-time faculty often commute between institutions and prepare courses on a grueling timetable, making enormous sacrifices to maintain interaction with their students.

- "Freeway faculty" or "road scholars" teach at three or four different colleges simultaneously, often in different counties, to bypass caps on part-time hours at a single school
- Many supplement their teaching income with low-wage gig economy work—Uber driving, bagging groceries—sometimes at the same stores where their students shop
- Some teach up to six courses per semester—nearly double a typical full-time professor's load—just to reach survival-level income

Faculty on contingent appointments are typically paid only for the hours they spend in the classroom. While they may be excellent teachers, they are not given adequate institutional support for time spent meeting with students, evaluating student work, and class planning and preparation. (AAUP (American Association of University Professors) Background Facts on Contingent Faculty Positions)

- 22% report having anxiety about accessing adequate food, with another 6 percent reporting reduced food intake due to lack of resources ("New AFT Report: Adjunct Faculty Remain Underpaid" 2023)

Financial Precarity

- 74% of adjuncts live paycheck to paycheck, with only 15% able to comfortably cover basic monthly expenses.
- The "Adjunct Penalty" means earning half of what non-tenure track teaching faculty do for the same work.

Survival Strategies

- 26% of adjunct faculty—people who work on temporary contracts, semester to semester—have trouble accessing enough food (AFT 2020)
- Nearly 25% of adjunct faculty rely on at least one public assistance program (SNAP, Medicaid, or EITC) due to poverty (AFT 2020)

Total Advanced Degrees (Master's + Professional + Doctorate):

- 2007–2010: Roughly 135,000–330,000 recipients
- 2024–25: **~650,000–730,000 recipients** (a 240% increase from 2010)

No Safety Net, No Stability

Zero Job Security

- Faculty in contingent positions often receive little or no evaluation and mentoring, making them especially vulnerable to being dismissed over one or two student complaints. (AAUP (American Association of University Professors) Background Facts on Contingent Faculty Positions)
- For 75% of adjuncts, employment is only guaranteed for a term or semester at a time ("New AFT Report: Adjunct Faculty Remain Underpaid" 2023)
- **Late Notice:** Nearly 43% of adjuncts receive teaching assignments less than one month before classes begin, making financial planning nearly impossible (Johnson & Fuesting 2026)
- **Unpaid Risk:** At 70% of institutions, courses are canceled if enrollment drops. Adjuncts typically receive zero compensation for the lost preparation and work. (Johnson & Fuesting 2026)

- At 13% of institutions, low enrollment may reduce adjunct pay rates. Some places (4%) pay incrementally based on the number of students enrolled in a course.
- **International scholars on visas face unique, existential precarity:** visa status (F-1, H-1B, J-1) may depend on continuous employment, making the threat of job loss not just financial but existential (deportation, separation from family, loss of ability to work in the U.S.). They cannot access many safety net benefits U.S. citizens can (unemployment, SNAP, Medicaid), face additional employment restrictions, and may be unable to work second jobs to supplement income. The power imbalance is extreme—institutions hold their ability to remain in the country (Kezar et al.; Childress 2019).

The Benefits Gap

- No health insurance or retirement benefits (AAUP (American Association of University Professors) Background Facts on Contingent Faculty Positions) — even when carrying full-time course loads
 - Only 14% of part-time faculty get health benefits from another employer; for 78%, their work as faculty is their primary employment, yet only a third get health insurance through their college or university (CFT 2022)
- Melissa Bruninga-Matteau, in 2012, started a conversation regarding how she, as a white, 43-year-old single mother with a Ph.D. in medieval history who teaches two humanities courses as an adjunct professor at Yavapai College, in Prescott, Ariz., came to rely on food stamps and Medicaid
 - She said the stereotype of the people receiving such aid does not reflect reality.
 - "Recipients include growing numbers of people like her, the highly educated, whose advanced degrees have not insulated them from financial hardship." (Patton 2012)

Reliance on Public Assistance

Institutional Invisibility

- But no matter how qualified and dedicated, faculty teaching in these positions are hobbled in the performance of their duties by a lack of professional treatment and support. Many lack access to such basics as offices, computer support, and photocopying services. (AAUP (American Association of University Professors) Background Facts on Contingent Faculty Positions)
- Faculty in contingent positions, though they may teach the majority of some types of courses, are often cut out of department and institution-wide planning. The knowledge that they have about their students and the strengths and weaknesses of the courses they teach is not taken into consideration. (AAUP (American Association of University Professors) Background Facts on Contingent Faculty Positions)

Chronic Underemployment

Three-quarters of adjuncts would gladly take additional course assignments if available, but are blocked by institutional administrative caps designed to avoid triggering benefit eligibility thresholds—creating artificial scarcity in their own employment. Under the Affordable Care Act, employers must provide health insurance to employees working more than 30 hours per week; many colleges responded by implementing strict limits on course credits and work hours per semester, deliberately capping adjuncts below full-time status to avoid insurance obligations. This practice has prompted advocacy for policy reform, exemplified by California Assembly Bill 2277, which would have raised the cap for part-time faculty to 85% of a full-time load (approximately four courses at a single community college).

However, Governor Gavin Newsom vetoed the bill on September 22, 2024, arguing in his veto message that "this bill continues to create unknown, but potentially significant costs or cost pressures in the millions to tens of millions of dollars." The Association of California Community College Administrators opposed the bill, warning that "AB 2277 would infringe upon the local authority of community college districts to collectively bargain their own paid leave provisions at the district level," and noting concerns that "allowing part-time faculty members to teach more courses at a single campus could trigger the Affordable Care Act, requiring colleges to expand health care coverage for part-timers"—illustrating how the ACA itself has become a tool for institutional cost-cutting and the suppression of adjunct work opportunities (Johnson & Fuesting 2026; AFT; CalMatters)

Mental Health

Depression

- Depression rates among adjunct faculty are 2–3 times higher than those of the general population (AFT 2020, 2022; Evans et al. 2018; Tucker et al. 2022; Levecque et al. 2017)
 - Nearly 45 percent of faculty members surveyed have put off getting needed healthcare, including mental health services, and 64 percent have forgone dental care (AFT 2020)
- Suicidal ideation has been documented among contingent faculty

The Cognitive Tax

Financial precarity creates a constant mental bandwidth drain that impairs professional performance and personal relationships.

The Exist Strategy

Shame, Silence & Isolation

Higher education—which should model ethical labor practices and value knowledge work—instead leads the race to the bottom, demonstrating that even terminal degrees offer no protection from exploitation. This sends a chilling message across the economy (Giroux 2014; Slaughter & Rhoades 2004).

The "Performing Professor"

- Higher education uniquely exploits workers' passion, calling, and commitment. Universities leverage instructors' love of teaching, intellectual commitment to their disciplines, dedication to students, and identification as teachers and scholars to extract labor far beyond what's compensated or sustainable. "Do it for the students," "Do it for the love of learning," "Teaching is a calling, not just a job"—these narratives become justifications for exploitation, suggesting that expecting fair pay and decent conditions means you don't really care or don't belong in academia (Childress; Bousquet; Kezar et al.).
- Passion and calling are weaponized against workers, making them complicit in their own exploitation and feel guilty for expecting basic dignity (Childress; Bousquet).
- The system relies on people's hope, desperation, sunk costs, and identity. Adjuncts continue in exploitative conditions because: they hope for a tenure-track job (the academic lottery ticket—keep buying tickets even though odds are 1 in 100+), they've invested 5-10+ years in education and training (PhD plus often postdocs) and can't psychologically accept that it was for nothing (sunk cost fallacy), they identify deeply as teachers, scholars, historians, philosophers, sociologists—it's not just what they

do but who they are, and they have few alternatives with specialized degrees (what does one do with a PhD in medieval literature or continental philosophy besides teach). The system exploits all of these psychological and structural vulnerabilities (Cassuto; Childress; Bousquet).

- **The "mommy penalty" in academia is severe:** Women with children are less likely to be hired, promoted, or tenured, and more likely to be relegated to contingent positions (Misra et al.; Guarino & Borden).
- **Adjuncts of color are less likely to be hired, less likely to be paid fairly, and face racist evaluations from students and administrators that threaten contract renewals** (Griffin et al.; Flaherty).

Fear of Disclosure

Academia's prestige masks its exploitative labor practices. From the outside, being a college professor sounds prestigious, intellectual, secure, and middle-class—tenure, summers off, intellectual freedom, respect. The reality of adjuncting—poverty wages, no security, no benefits, no respect, no intellectual life (no time for research or reading), grueling working conditions—shocks people outside academia who assume "professor" means security and status. This gap between cultural perception and lived reality adds to adjuncts' shame and isolation—people don't understand why they're struggling, assume they're exaggerating or bad with money, and offer unhelpful advice ("Just get a real job," "Why did you get a PhD if there are no jobs?") (Childress 2019; Kezar et al.).

The prestige of the PhD becomes a curse: It represents both immense achievement and devastating failure—the credential that was supposed to ensure middle-class security instead ensures precarity (Cassuto; Childress 2019).

Social Fracture

The Inhumane Cost: Healthcare Rationing

- Nearly half of faculty members surveyed have put off getting needed healthcare, including mental health services, and 68 percent have forgone dental care ("New AFT Report: Adjunct Faculty Remain Underpaid" 2023)
- Faculty are rationing healthcare due to a lack of or insufficient coverage (CFT 2022):
 - 63% postponed dental care/checkups
 - 44% postponed needed healthcare, including mental health services
 - 43% did not see a doctor when needed
 - 30% did not get medical tests/treatments recommended by doctors
 - 21% chose less expensive treatments than recommended
 - 19% did not fill prescriptions
 - 12% skipped/postponed rehabilitation care
 - 11% cut pills in half or skipped doses of medicine
- **Chronic illnesses may develop or worsen under the stress and deprivation of adjunct life—** autoimmune conditions, cardiovascular disease, diabetes—without access to care (Kenner & Bacon 2019; Childress 2019).

How We Got Here - This Crisis Was Structurally and Deliberately Built

The makeup of the US academic workforce has shifted from mostly full-time tenured or tenure-track faculty members to mostly faculty members holding contingent appointments that are ineligible for tenure (AAUP

2025).

Key statistics from fall 1987 to fall 2023:

- **Tenure-track decline:** About 32 percent of faculty members held full-time tenured or tenure-track appointments in fall 2023, compared with about 53 percent in fall 1987 (AAUP 2025)
- **Tenured positions:** About 23 percent held full-time tenured appointments, compared with about 39 percent in fall 1987 (AAUP 2025)
- **Contingent appointments:** About 68 percent of faculty members held contingent appointments in fall 2023, compared with about 47 percent in fall 1987—a complete reversal of the historical norm (AAUP 2025)
- **Part-time work:** Nearly half (49 percent) of faculty members were employed part-time in fall 2023, compared with about 33 percent in fall 1987 (AAUP 2025)

Contingency rates by institution type (Fall 2023): The percentage of faculty members holding contingent appointments ranged from about 51 percent among Research I universities to about 83 percent among associate's (community) colleges—reflecting the disproportionate reliance on contingent labor in the institutions serving the most vulnerable student populations (AAUP 2025).

Recent trends (Fall 2002 to Fall 2023): The number of faculty members holding contingent appointments increased substantially while tenure-track positions stagnated or declined:

- Full-time contingent appointments increased about 65 percent
- Full-time tenured appointments increased about 6 percent
- Full-time tenure-track appointments decreased about 7 percent
- Part-time appointments increased about 20 percent (AAUP 2025)

Contract types: Most full-time contingent faculty members are on renewable contracts, while most part-time contingent faculty members are on nonrenewable less-than-annual contracts. About 76 percent of part-time contingent faculty were on nonrenewable short-term contracts in fall 2023, while about 85 percent of full-time contingent faculty were on renewable (annual or multiyear) contracts (AAUP 2025).

Graduate student employment: US colleges and universities have increasingly relied on graduate student employees for teaching and research—the number of graduate student employees with teaching or research responsibilities increased by over 40 percent from fall 2002 to fall 2023 (AAUP 2025).

- Universities deliberately overproduce PhD graduates through their graduate programs — training far more scholars than available tenure-track positions (Larson et al. 2014)
- This creates a surplus of desperate, highly educated workers with no job security (Larson et al. 2014)

Where The Money Goes

- Non-instructional administrative staff nearly doubled from the 1980s onward (AAUP; Kezar et al.; Ginsberg 2011)
- University president salaries exploded — reaching \$500,000–\$1,000,000+ annually (Ginsberg 2011)
- The budget crisis was manufactured: there was money for expansion and executive compensation, but not for faculty dignity (Ginsberg 2011; Newfield 2016)

Actionable Solutions

Resistance and Organizations

Adjunct unionization is growing as instructors organize for better pay, benefits, job security, and working conditions. Unions like SEIU (Service Employees International Union), AFT (American Federation of Teachers), AAUP (American Association of University Professors), and independent faculty unions have organized adjuncts at hundreds of institutions, winning significant improvements: pay increases (sometimes 30-50%+), access to health insurance, job security provisions (seniority systems, multi-year contracts), grievance procedures, professional development funding, and inclusion in governance. Unionization has measurably improved adjunct working conditions where it exists (Berry; Rhoades; McNaughtan et al.).

Adjunct organizing faces intense opposition from administrations who threaten, intimidate, surveil, and retaliate against organizers, delay contract negotiations for years, claim poverty while sitting on massive endowments, and manipulate worker classifications to prevent unionization (Berry; Rhoades).

Landmark campaigns like the "Adjunct Project" collected data crowdsourcing adjunct pay rates, exposing the exploitation and making it visible. The #AdjunctCrisis hashtag campaigns raised awareness

National Adjunct Walkout Day and organizing efforts have made the exploitation visible, disrupted operations, and forced public conversations. Media coverage of adjunct poverty (articles in The Atlantic, The Chronicle of Higher Education, Inside Higher Ed) has changed public perception (Berry; Childress 2019).

Student solidarity matters and is growing. When students understand that their instructors are struggling—living in cars, skipping meals, unable to afford healthcare—they can advocate for better institutional practices, recognize that their education quality is tied to instructor working conditions, and join campaigns demanding change. Students have organized rallies, written petitions, testified at board meetings, and refused to cross picket lines in support of adjunct faculty (Berry; McNaughtan et al.).

Student-adjunct alliances are powerful because students have moral authority and institutions care about their satisfaction (customers) in ways they don't care about adjunct well-being (Berry).

Resistance comes at great personal risk for adjuncts, who can be easily fired for organizing, speaking publicly, or even just associating with union efforts. Contingent workers have none of the academic freedom protections that tenure provides. Organizers have been blacklisted across institutions, had contracts not renewed in retaliation, faced legal threats, and experienced professional destruction for demanding basic dignity. The courage required to organize under these conditions is immense (Berry; Bousquet).

Tenure-track faculty solidarity is essential but often lacking. Some tenured faculty organize alongside contingent colleagues, using their privilege and protection to shield vulnerable workers. Others ignore, minimize, or benefit from exploitation, enjoying smaller classes and reduced service because adjuncts absorb the teaching and are excluded from governance. Academic labor solidarity across tiers is necessary for transformative change (Berry; Rhoades; American Association of University Professors).

Positive Examples

Some institutions have converted adjunct lines to full-time lecturer positions with better pay (\$40,000-\$60,000+), benefits, multi-year contracts (3-5 years), pathways to continuing/permanent status, and inclusion in governance—proving that change is possible when there's political will. These conversions should be celebrated as victories while recognizing they're insufficient—the goal should be tenure-track or equivalent permanent positions (McNaughtan et al.; Rhoades).

- At the City University of New York, union negotiations secured three-year appointments for adjuncts meeting certain criteria, providing genuine economic security
- At Rutgers University, the AAUP-AFT negotiated four-semester appointments for part-time faculty with 12+ years of service
- At the University of California, union contracts mandate escalating appointment lengths: one year initially, two years for the second reappointment, and three years for all subsequent appointments

Repeat

Higher education is a public good, essential to democracy, social mobility, innovation, and informed citizenship, and its quality depends fundamentally on the well-being, stability, and support of its instructors. Exploiting adjuncts degrades education for everyone—not just adjuncts, but students who deserve excellent teaching and society that depends on educated citizens (Newfield 2016; Readings; Giroux 2014).

Students are being cheated. They (and their families, and taxpayers in public systems) pay tens of thousands of dollars in tuition expecting quality education from supported, secure, fairly compensated educators who can invest fully in their learning—not instructors living in cars and cycling through multiple institutions just to survive. The financial exploitation of adjuncts subsidizes administrative bloat, luxury facilities, and endowment growth while undermining the core mission of teaching and learning ("Recent Trends in the Cost of College"; Ginsberg 2011; Figlio et al. 2015).

The social contract is broken—a betrayal and fraud. Society told these individuals to get advanced degrees, that education was the path to stable, meaningful work and middle-class security, that a PhD was the highest achievement guaranteeing respect and livelihood. Then it abandoned them to poverty and precarity, blaming them for circumstances structurally created. This betrayal undermines faith in education, meritocracy, and institutions (Cassuto; Childress 2019; Bousquet).

This is a moral issue and human rights crisis. Allowing highly educated, skilled people to live in poverty—experiencing food and housing insecurity, unable to access healthcare, suffering mental health crises without support—while administrators earn \$500,000-\$1,000,000+ salaries and universities accumulate billion-dollar endowments is morally unconscionable, a grotesque injustice that violates basic human dignity. We have the resources; we're choosing not to use them to support human beings doing essential work ("How Harvard University's Funding Works"; "Report Shows Alarming Poverty"; Kenner & Bacon 2019; Ginsberg 2011).

In Memoriam

- The death of Margaret Mary Vojtko — an 83-year-old adjunct professor who died in poverty after decades of service — became a symbol of the crisis
"Margaret Mary Vojtko, an 83-year-old adjunct professor of French, died in poverty after 25 years of loyal service. She had no retirement plan, no medical benefits, and was facing homelessness."
- After 25 years of teaching French at Duquesne, the university had not renewed her contract.
- As a part-time professor, she had been earning about \$10,000 a year, and had no health insurance.
- Daniel Kovalik, senior counsel to the Steelworkers union, says Vojtko was distraught. "She had cancer; she had very high medical bills," Kovalik says.
- Vojtko died Sept. 1 after a heart attack at the age of 83, destitute and nearly homeless.
- Duquesne had cut her to one class per semester, reducing her income to under \$10,000, during her last year according to an article "Throwaway Faculty" by The Progressive Magazine in June 2014
 - Also, her cancer returned, piling huge medical bills on her back

- With no savings or university pension, she'd become so pauperized that she couldn't pay her electric bill, effectively making her homeless that winter
- Her stress level was off the charts, yet she never missed a day of class
- Until last spring, that is. That's when Duquesne let her go.
- On September 1, this proud professional educator was found sprawled on her front lawn, having suffered a massive heart attack
- She died penniless, jobless, and literally heartbroken, having been thrown away by the university that had used her for twenty-five years

Conclusion

The adjunct crisis is not an accident, a natural market outcome, or a temporary budget problem—it's a deliberate, systematic restructuring of higher education that prioritizes profit maximization over people, educational mission, and human dignity (Bousquet; Slaughter & Rhoades 2004; Kezar et al.), exploits workers' passion, credentials, and desperation (Childress 2019; Cassuto), and treats teaching—the core work of education—as a commodity and expendable gig work rather than a skilled profession worthy of investment, support, and respect (Umbach 2007; Ehrenberg & Zhang 2005).

Highly educated, deeply committed, brilliant instructors are living in poverty, experiencing food and housing insecurity (Kenner & Bacon 2019; "Report Shows Alarming Poverty"; Goldrick-Rab et al. 2015), suffering mental health crises without access to care (Evans et al. 2018; Levecque et al. 2017; Tucker et al. 2022), and being denied the basic dignity of stable employment and living wages—all while doing the majority of undergraduate teaching at American colleges and universities (June; Johnson & Fuesting 2026; American Association of University Professors) and being told their exploitation is necessary, inevitable, or somehow their own fault for "choosing" humanities fields or not being "competitive enough" for jobs that don't exist (Cassuto; Larson et al. 2014; Roy et al.).

This system harms adjuncts catastrophically, degrades educational quality measurably (Umbach 2007; Figlio et al. 2015; Jaeger & Eagan), betrays students who deserve better ("Their Wellbeing Affects Our Wellbeing"; Ehrenberg & Zhang 2005), and corrupts the mission and integrity of higher education as an institution dedicated to knowledge, truth, and human flourishing (Readings; Ginsberg 2011; Giroux 2014).

Adjuncts are not "temporary," "supplemental," or "part-time"—they are the teaching workforce

(Johnson & Fuesting 2026; Government Accountability Office), and they deserve living wages that allow them to afford housing and healthcare, job security that allows them to plan beyond the current semester, full benefits including health insurance and retirement, respect as the credentialed professionals and experts they are, offices and resources to do their work effectively, and the institutional support necessary to teach well and live with dignity (American Association of University Professors; "New AFT Report: Adjunct Faculty Remain Underpaid"; Berry).

Until higher education reckons honestly with this exploitation, names it as such, and commits to transformative structural change—not cosmetic improvements or small pay bumps, but fundamental reinvestment in teaching as valued work deserving of tenure-track or equivalent permanent, secure, fairly compensated positions (Kezar et al.; Schuster & Finkelstein 2006; Newfield 2016)—the crisis will deepen, more brilliant people will be destroyed by a system that trained them and then discarded them (Cassuto; Childress 2019; Evans et al. 2018), and everyone invested in education, knowledge, justice, and human dignity should be outraged, organizing, and demanding better (Berry; Rhoades; Bousquet).

The current system is morally bankrupt, intellectually indefensible, and unsustainable. We can do better. We must do better. Adjuncts, students, and the future of education depend on it.